

SUCCESSFUL ARGUMENTATIVE STRATEGIES IN DEBATING

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When English debate was established in Thailand in 1995 by Chulalongkorn University with the support of Dr. Omar Salahhudin, from Malaysia, it was tournament oriented. Then, beginning in 2007, many programs were influenced by Professor Alfred Snider, who said, "Debate is for everyone, and everyone can debate" (Snider, 2008, p.11). Professor Snider helped to demonstrate the importance of debate as a tool for educational development, whereas other experts define debate as "a disagreement in which two sides take opposing positions on an issue," (Hanson, 1991, p. 44), "a decision-making tool" and "a form of persuasion," (Trapp et al. 2005, p. 3, 5), "an organized public form of argument," and "an organized public argument on a specific topic" (Shuster & Meany, 2005, p 44). Debate, for Dr. Snider, could be viewed as "a sport of mind" that is about "change" and that is "essential and vital to democracy" (Snider's talk in Thailand, 2008). Debate can thus serve as an effective educational tool to empower individual English language learners in Thailand, particularly when the country is now working towards democracy.

Much has been written on the rhetorical and linguistic structure of arguments and on academic writing in general, but little has been written on how to teach argument (Wingate, 2012). While Snider et al. (2008) suggest the A-R-E Format (Assertion, Reason and Evidence) can be used to teach students to make strong arguments, few studies have focused on a detailed examination of the argumentative patterns

debaters actually use to win debates using debates as a corpus.

This article is based on the research, “An Investigation of Successful Argumentative Strategies in Debating,” supported by the Rachadapiseksompot Endowment Fund, Chulalongkorn University. This study operated from the foundation that some arguments are more persuasive and convincing and, thus, more successful than others. It explores both strategy and argument, in which strategy is a planned-for series of actions for achieving something - i.e. the conscious use of patterns of arguments, moves and techniques, or “the conscious decision to or not to perform any actions to win a debate” (Salahuddin, 2005 p.8). Snider (2005) said strategy is the use of all types of passionate manner and use of language, like exclamatory rhetoric, incorporating effective word devices and effective sentence structures, rhetorical questions, and repetition. Salahuddin (2005) also includes paralinguistic aspects, such as tone, pitch, speed, pace, pause, emphatic stress, and visual expression, including gestures, eye contact and humor. Strategy in debating is “an approach or technique related to ‘Matter, Manner and Method’ that form the trinity known as the 3Ms, which when used together are essentially the measuring stick for assessing effective performance within differing debating styles” (Salahuddin, 2005 p. 5). Snider (2008) points out that whatever the style, the process used in debating is the same, and the Roles of Speakers are similar. At many debate workshops conducted in different countries, Professor Snider emphasized the ability to handle points of information (POI’s), questions raised by opponents to speakers during the time allowed in the speech. He also stressed that this can be done by asking precise and concise questions at the right time using the technique called “KISS or Keep

It Short and Simple” (Snider’s talk in Thailand, 2008 and 2012) to win a debate.

This article reflects only one aspect of the four research questions focusing on the Matter and Method for possible success in debate.

Framework for Investigating Arguments

Combining the Toulmin model of argument, as revised and presented by Trapp (2005), three types of patterns of argumentation were adapted as the research framework using the “A-R-E Format” (Snider & Schnurer, 2006 p. 25). Each pattern type contains:

- “A” - assertion, the central argument embracing the concept of belief
- “R” - the warrant or reason that the statement is true, and
- “E” - evidence, support for the assertion and reasoning with reservation as an optional component.

Three types of the A-R-E Model were used:

a Single Argument (A-R-E);

a Convergent Argument (A-R-E-E), having two pieces of evidence; and

an Independent Argument (A-R-E-R-E), an assertion with two independent reasons, each of which has its own piece of evidence.

Arguments judged successful by experts in the field of argumentation were examined, with specific interest in the evaluation of the rhetoric employed.

Research Methodology and Procedure

Data Collection

The research used a mixed method approach, qualitative and quantitative, with triangulation data: video clips, written data, and interviews. The corpus of material was formed from interviews and debate speeches previously recorded from the final rounds of prestigious international debates. These tournaments included the Worlds Universities Debating Championship (Worlds), the World Universities Invitational Peace Debating Championship (WUPID), the AustralAsia Intervarsity Debating Championship, and the All-Asian Intervarsity Debating Championships. For the study, sixty-five championship-winning speeches of ten debates were selected. Professor Snider, Dr. Salahuddin, and the researcher were at six of the ten debates as adjudicators or observers. Interviews with five percent of these successful debaters as well as world grand finalist adjudicators were conducted to provide different perspectives of successful argumentative strategies. The corpus itself was then justified as successful.

Data Analysis

Content analysis was conducted searching for debating strategies examining the written transcription of 105,541 words of sixty-five speeches; forty-five speeches containing POIs and their video clips were scrutinized for POI strategies. Also the paralinguistic transcription and video clips of fourteen champions were observed for visual and paralinguistic aspects of successful argumentative strategies. Interviews were conducted through email for content analysis and discussion with winners, a champion debater, and an adjudicator. The validation of this analysis was conducted by the researcher and randomly checked by a native English teacher.

Discourse analysis, using the three A-R-E Model

patterns of arguments, was carried out to investigate 47,419 words of thirty-one selected constructive speeches containing the development and patterns of arguments, validated and approved by an emeritus member of the Worlds Universities Debating Council. Frequency counts of the use of all patterns were also conducted to see the preferred patterns of arguments employed.

For quantitative analysis, two computer software programs (RightWriter and Concordance) were used to examine sixty-five speeches (105,541 words) for frequency counts and a speech functional analysis.

Research Findings

Strategies

Based on the interviews, there were three main types of strategies: debate tactics and dealing with points of information (questions raised by opponents to the speaker during the permitted time of the speech), style, and the use of the power of language. This article covers the first two.

The five debate tactics include the following. Argument prioritization is the first tactic debaters used to determine effective team and time management to meet the standard of acceptability, relevance, and sufficiency based on order of importance and roles of speakers. Rebutting was used to marginalize and wrong-foot opponents exposing flaws, untrue or less important materials, or wrong philosophy, logical weaknesses, factual misrepresentation, or weak reasoning. Successful debaters employed concession to reduce rebuttal issues and establish fewer, particularly critical areas of opposing argumentation. Many used sound-bites or a summary of a whole point of view in a single, easily understood and remembered sentence

pre-empting opposition weakness. Then, the speaker was obliged to discuss an argument flaw, rather than conveniently bypass it. Finally, winners also used humor with sophisticated language and compelling emotions to rebut effectively. These rebuttals rendered opponents' points less significant and, as such, were accorded a lower weight than what their opponents claimed. Others mentioned using the flipside of an argument as the basis for rebuttal.

When dealing with POIs, it was evident from the findings that winners remained extremely dynamic by offering POIs throughout the debate, many at the same time. Of all 45 POI corpus speeches, as many as 416 detected POIs raised acted as an instrument of interruption. All 78 POIs taken were concise and effective, reflecting "Snider's KISS." Among these, the shortest POI was only eight words in length while 31% of POIs ranged from 11 to 20 words and over half ranged from 11 to 30 words. Only 14% of POIs taken were phrased in more than 40 words. 75.64% of 78 POIs taken lasted less than 10 seconds and 19.23% between 11 and 15 seconds while only 5.12% lasted longer than 15 seconds. A champion recommended that POIs be short and not be answerable in "yes" or "no" terms, focusing on a core inconsistency or weak logic to throw the opponents off their rhythm. An interview corpus shows winners accepted POIs from the strongest opponents to challenge them and prove their dynamic reactive ability to mount strong impromptu attacks and yet rapidly regain their team stance and line of argumentation.

Patterns of Arguments

The analysis of thirty-one transcribed constructive speeches using the A-R-E Model framework revealed four types of patterns of argumentation. Three of these

types meet the framework presented by Professor Snider. They include Single Arguments (A-R-E), Convergent Arguments (A-R-E-E), and Independent Arguments (A-R-E-R-E). One new type of argument pattern, which has not been previously identified, was found, "Mixed Argument," (A-R-E-E/R-E/R-E-E). It has several individual strands of reasoning and evidence as shown in Figure 1 (see supplemental material online).

The corpus also reveals that an independent argument was the most popular type employed; 48% of 31 speeches utilized this type, and a mixed argument is the second most commonly used type, with 38% recorded across the sample. Convergent and single arguments were utilized only twice each (7% each) as shown in Table 1.

Table 1. Frequency of patterns of argumentation

Type of Argument	Number of Speeches
Simple Argument	2
Convergent Argument	2
Mixed Argument	12
Independent Argument	15

This preference might be because a single argument lacks the necessary sophistication and complexity expected at the highest levels of debating competitions. While a convergent argument might appear more convincing in theory, having an assertion with reasoning accompanied by several evidential strands, it still suffers from the absence of reasons, a flaw which can be detrimental to winning a debate. The independent argument, with its many lines of reasoning supported by individual pieces of evidence, is then preferable to

justify the assertions with more than one reason. This then makes the argument more valid and likely to win a debate. In short, the occurrences of both independent and mixed arguments together were found as often as 87% of the time (27 out of 31 speeches); therefore, it is far better to follow the independent and mixed argument patterns when constructing arguments to win a debate.

Pedagogical Implementation and Implication

Due to the needs for better and effective education for the grass roots level in Thailand, debate appears to be an excellent tool for educational development as inspired by Professor Snider. The pedagogical implementation of this study was thus geared towards teacher training instead of teaching and coaching university students to debate and win. Based on the findings of the four A-R-E Model argumentative patterns intertwined with strategies, style, and the power of language, the course “Building Skills for Debate: Critical Thinking, Argumentation and Debate” has been designed. Funded by the Bureau of Educational Innovation Development of the Office of Basic Education, Ministry of Education, Thailand, it is meant to be an extra-curricular course for all public schools nationwide. As a part of material construction, three projects were conducted during 2014-2016 for elementary and high schools. Eighty selected teachers participated in two workshops on “Adjudication Training and Testing,” and the first trial workshop of the course materials. The second project covered eight trial workshops held in six regions with twenty-five outstanding teachers of the first workshop serving as training assistants. The third was the Regional Secondary School English Debate Competition 2016 having more than 100 schools, 240 teams, 240 teachers, and 960 students participating.

The quantitative feedback from all the teacher-training workshops with 380 participants reveals that teachers found the A-R-E formats lead to a better understanding of argumentation and are a more effective tool to teach basic debate. In late 2016, three of the 25 training assistants conducted a study on critical thinking and the use of A-R-E, two (Tharich and Tharach Puttarak) at their schools and one (Kitirong Boonkong) at five regional English Camps. It is expected that similar projects will be held in the coming years with the hope to expand to other subjects, and thus, more teachers will be trained to teach argumentation and debate and more students will learn step by step how to develop convergent, independent, and mixed arguments when they reach intermediate and advanced levels. These patterns can also been employed to initiate other critical thinking activities and platforms that can lead to more effective discussion and negotiation skills.

Conclusion

As shown through this research, successful argumentative strategies offer significant potential for the improvement of teaching and learning of English through their direct application. The contribution of A-R-E has a great impact on the development of critical thinking and effective communication, and debate. It can also enhance teacher professional development.

Professor Snider certainly had, and will always have, an influence on our educational development. The newest edition of “Building Skills for Debate” will be published in 2017 and distributed to 30,176 schools throughout Thailand. His wish to “Replace weapons with words...logic, and love” will unquestionably be a voice in the sky heard time and again in debate and education.

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